of a larger engagement with the world. Modulations accordingly reflect not just the bilateral dynamic but the global situation as a whole.

It is worthwhile to dwell for a moment here on the relevance of the West in the unfolding of India–China relations. This is often the subject of Chinese polemics, and Indians then tend to go on the defensive. There is no question that given its dominance, the West has been very much a factor of calculations for both parties. But the record shows that it is actually China that has been more active in bringing it into play.

For two decades after the PRC was founded, India's ties with the West were relatively much better, though there were issues of divergence. Indeed, China itself was key among them, especially between India and the US during the Nehru–Krishna Menon period. It was, therefore, something of an irony that as ties worsened over the border dispute, China's portrayal of India's relationship with the West started to change. When we finally did turn to the West, it was actually only as Chinese forces overwhelmed Indian defences in November 1962. Yet within a decade, it was China that made a sharp about-turn through its rapprochement with the US, reflected in the visits of Henry Kissinger and Richard Nixon. The resulting China–Pakistan–US triangle, thereafter, posed a serious challenge that could be answered only through the Indo-Soviet Treaty of 1971.

It is noteworthy that in pursuance of its interests, China had no hesitation in establishing global coordination with the Western bloc. There was a time when it even publicly advocated the formation of a 'single line' of nations in the same latitude (China, the US, Japan and Europe) to counter the USSR and its friends. Vietnam was kept in check through direct pressure and India, more indirectly, through Pakistan. This was the history that was sought to be put behind when India and China came to terms pragmatically in 1988.

But it is still one worth recalling for many reasons. To start with, China had built up enough constituencies of support in the West to insulate its economic cooperation from whatever political differences may crop up from time to time. This allowed it to reap economic and technological rewards while still engaging in political disputation. India must, therefore, fall neither for a simplistic description of national contradictions nor assume a zero-sum game between China and the West. Then, for all the homilies that are now handed out about the evil intentions of the West, Indians would do well to remember the advocacy of a China–US G2 last